

Exercise

## ALL PARTS ARE WELCOME

**DIRECTIONS:** In IFS our credo is: All parts are welcome! Here is an exercise to help you welcome all of your parts.

Turn your attention inside and begin with this offer:

"I want to help anyone who needs help. To do that, I need to know all of you."

Then provide this information:

"If you overwhelm me, I can't be there to help you."

And make this request:

"Please be here with me rather than taking me over and, when you're ready, let me know who you are. I will write this down."

Write down the parts (thoughts, feelings or sensations) that you hear, see or sense inside (use extra paper if needed):

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## Exercise

# GETTING TO KNOW UNPOPULAR PARTS

**DIRECTIONS:** When we choose a target part, we need de facto permission from all other parts in order to communicate with it. To find out who might object, we ask the client "How do you feel toward this part?" As we locate reactive parts we try to persuade them to separate (that is, unblend) and let us proceed with the target part. Some target parts are particularly extreme and unpopular and will evoke a big reaction. This is an exercise for getting to know unpopular parts.

Find a target part, write it down (use extra paper to draw it if you wish):

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Notice how you feel toward this part and make a list of every feeling:

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If you are doing this alone, embody each reactive part, allowing it to do (that is, direct your posture and your movements) and say what it wishes by way of introduction.

**THEN ASK IT:** "Why do you feel this way toward" (the target part)?

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**ONCE YOU UNDERSTAND, ASK:** "Will you trust me to get to know (the target part) so I can help with this problem?"

**IF THE ANSWER IS NO, ASK:** "Are you willing to let me get to know you better?"

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**IF THE ANSWER IS YES,** thank the part and move on to the next until you have permission from all of them.

**RETURN TO THE TARGET PART AND ASK:**

- "Did you watch me negotiate with those parts who react so strongly to you?"
- "What was that like for you?"
- "What do you want me – and those parts – to know about your job and how you are trying to help?"
- "What would happen if you stopped doing this job?"
- "If we could help that part would you need to keep doing this?"

Finally, set an intention to return and help with the underlying problem (the part) this protector has named.

## GOING INSIDE TO IDENTIFY PARTS

**DIRECTIONS:** Follow the prompts, and adjust as needed. You may want to write down or record what your notice.

- Settle into a comfortable position.
- Notice your back against the chair, your feet on the floor and your contact with the ground.
- Close your eyes and take a couple deep breaths if that feels comfortable. Notice.
- Focus your attention inside and notice any thoughts, feelings or sensations that show up.
  - You may notice physical sensations – some may be pleasant, others may be unpleasant.
  - You may notice one feeling or many feelings.
  - You may hear one thought or many thoughts competing with each other.
  - You may notice blankness or foggy inside. That's okay.
- You may also notice your mind wanting to distract you and shift your focus away from that sensation, feeling or thought.
- Be curious about whatever you notice.
  - What does it want you to know?
  - What is it holding for you?
- If you can, send it gratitude for showing up, even if what you have noticed is negative.
- Notice how the part responds to your gratitude.
- When you feel ready, come back to the room.

Notice how your energy shifts when you focus your attention internally for a few minutes. Are you calmer, more peaceful or perhaps more agitated?

## THE 6Fs: THE STEPS WE USE TO HELP PROTECTIVE PARTS DIFFERENTIATE FROM THE SELF

The first three steps (find, focus, flesh out) involve helping parts to unblend.

1) **FIND** the part in, on or around the body.

- Who needs your attention right now?
- Where do you notice it?

2) **FOCUS** on it.

- Turn your attention inside.

3) **FLESH** it out.

- Can you see it?
  - If so, how does it look?
- If not, how do you experience it?
  - What is that like?
- How close are you to it?

4) How do you **FEEL** toward the part?

- This question is our Geiger Counter for Self-energy. Any answer that is not in the ballpark of the 8 C's means that a second part is influencing our thoughts.
  - We ask this second part if it is willing to relax so we can talk to the target part.
  - "If it is not willing to relax," we ask it what it needs us to know.
  - This process may lead us to a second (or third, fourth...) target part.
- Reactive parts often need to feel heard and validated. We stay with them until they are willing to let us get to know the target part.
- Once they agree, we ask the client, "How do you feel toward the (target) part now?"

5) Be**FRIEND** the part by finding out more about it.

- The fifth step involves learning about the target part and developing a friendly relationship. This builds relationships internally (Self to part) and externally (part to therapist).
  - "How did it get this job?"
  - "How effective is the job?"
  - "If it didn't have to do this job, what would it rather do?"
  - "How old is it?"
  - "How old does it think you are?"
  - "What else does it want you to know?"

6) What does this part **FEAR**?

- "What does it want for you?"
- "What would happen if it stopped doing this job?"

This key question will reveal any lurking polarization.

"If I stop feeling anxious, I'm afraid the suicidal part will take over." Or it will reveal the exile it protects.

"If I stop feeling anxious I'm afraid Jane will feel all alone and worthless."

## Exercise

# FIND, FOCUS ON AND FLESH OUT A TARGET PART

**DIRECTIONS:** This exercise walks you through the process of locating a target part. You may want to record the instructions below on a phone or other device so you can listen to them. Begin by turning your attention inside.

- Breathe and go slow.
- Remind your parts that there is room for everyone.
- Notice sensations, feelings and thoughts.
  - Ask:  
"Who needs my attention?"

Write that down:

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- Continue to observe, be patient, and notice what shows up.
- Notice if any sensations, feelings or thoughts are being dismissed internally as insignificant or not real.

If so, start by being curious about the part who is trying to steer you this way. Write that down:

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If not, choose whatever comes to mind first as your starting point. Notice where this part (sensation, feeling, thought) is located in, on or around your body.

- Do you see the part?
- Feel it?
- Hear it?
- Sense it in some other way?

Write down what you notice:

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## GET TO KNOW A PART

This meditation is designed to help you get to know a little bit about a part that you want to help or change your relationship with.

- *If it feels good, go ahead and take a deep breath.*
- *And think of a part who you'd like get to know a little better.*
- *Go ahead and focus on that part wherever you find it, in, on or around your body.*  
— *If you can't focus on it, that's okay.*
- *Either way, notice how you feel toward it.*
- *If you feel anything other than curiosity or acceptance, ask the reactive part if it would be willing to separate from you and not interfere just so you can learn more about your target part. We're not going to let it take over, we're just going to get to know it.*
- *And keep doing that with reactive parts until you feel curious about the original part.*
- *You may find that you don't get there, that other parts won't separate, which is okay. You can just spend the time listening to their fears about separating.*
- *But if they do let you feel at least curious about the original one then it's safe to listen.*
- *What does that original part want you to know about itself?*
- *What has the part been trying to do for you? To you?*
- *What might it need from you?*

I'll stop talking for a little while now and let you get to know it and then come back with time to return.

- *Okay, in the next few minutes we'll begin to come back.*
- *Thank the part for letting you know about it.*
- *And let it know this doesn't have to be its only chance to talk to you. If it wants, you can come back to it another time.*
- *And before you come back to this room, make sure you thank all the other parts for letting you get to know this one or letting you know that they were afraid if they didn't.*
- *And when all that feels complete, you can, if it feels right, begin to take some deep breaths again and shift your focus back to the outside.*

## Exercise

# FEEL TOWARD

**DIRECTIONS:** Locate a target part, focus on and flesh it out, and then ask:

"How do I feel toward \_\_\_\_\_ [the target part]?"

Write the answer down:

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If the answer is one of the feelings (or some simile) in the list below that indicates Self-energy, move on to befriending the part.

### FEELINGS THAT INDICATE THE CLIENT HAS SELF-ENERGY FOR THE TARGET PART:

- Curious
- Open
- Kindly
- Caring
- Connected
- Concerned
- Compassionate
- Loving

If, however, the answer is "I understand," you need to notice whether you are hearing from a manager who forestalls feelings by staying in thoughts and telling a story that sounds plausible; or if you really have a heartfelt connection with the part and you are aware how it feels.

If you are not sure where this "I understand" comes from, tell the target part what you understand and ask if you've got it right.

If, on the other hand, you hear "I agree with this part" then the part is not yet differentiated enough from you to have a conversation. Ask it to separate so you can talk.

And if the answer is any other feeling (for example, hatred, anger, fear, embarrassment) ask the part who feels that way: "What are you concerned would happen if you were to relax and let me talk to \_\_\_\_\_ (the target part)?"



Reactive parts commonly fear the target part in some way. Write down whatever you hear:

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If the reactive part fears the target part gaining too much influence, ask:

"If \_\_\_\_\_ (the target part) would agree not to take over, would you let me talk to it?"

If the reactive part replies:

"That will never work," you can reassure it in two ways, first by asking, "Can we hear from \_\_\_\_\_ (the target part) directly about whether it's willing to not take over?" And then by saying to the reactive part: "You're the boss. I'm not trying to make you do anything you're not comfortable with. But if you let me hear from both sides, I can help with this conflict between you and \_\_\_\_\_ (the target part.)"

## Exercise

# ASSESS SELF-ENERGY: FEEL TOWARD

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**DIRECTIONS:** For the sake of clarity, the target part in this exercise will be a chronically anxious part – but you can write in the part you hear about internally.

**ASK:** “How do you feel toward the \_\_\_\_\_ [anxious] part?”

- If the client is significantly differentiated from reactive parts and says something along the lines of “I’m curious” or “I care” then proceed and be curious: “What does this part want to tell you about itself?”
- But if the client has a negative reaction like “I hate it!”
- Or, the client expresses agreement along the lines “Of course I feel anxious.”

**ASK:** “Does this \_\_\_\_\_ (hating or agreeing) part need your attention first or would it be willing to relax and let you be curious about the \_\_\_\_\_ [anxious] part?”

- If the reactive part is willing to relax, repeat the original question: “How do you feel toward the \_\_\_\_\_ [anxious] part now?”
- If, however, the client goes on agreeing with the anxious part, we guide the client to inquire whether the anxious part is blended.

To do this, simply ask: “Is the \_\_\_\_\_ (anxious) part blended with you right now?”

- If yes: “Would it be willing to separate and meet you?” (meaning the client’s Self)
- If no then we explore more to find out who is agreeing: “Okay, somebody else agrees and maybe that part wants to say something. Let’s ask all the parts who agree on this issue to meet with you in a group. Would they be willing to do that? Invite them all to join you at a big conference table and see who shows up.”

After choosing a target part, the goal is to persuade reactive parts to unblend (differentiate), which will allow the client’s Self to be present and befriend the target part. When a part reacts negatively (or positively) to the target part and will not unblend, we move on to the method called “direct access.”

## BE WITH YOUR HEART

- *If it feels good, go ahead and take a deep breath and notice your heart in whatever way you experience it – this doesn't have to be your actual heart on the left side of your chest, just however you experience your heart.*
- *I'm going to invite you to get to know it in a physical way and we're going to explore different qualities of your heart.*
- *We'll see about its condition.*
  - *First notice how open it is.*
  - *How tender, encrusted or callused.*
  - *Perhaps it is congested, fluid or flowing.*
- *Also notice how much space your heart has in there.*
  - *Does it feel contracted and tightly packed or spacious?*
- *You might find in your exploration that different places in your heart are different in those ways.*
  - *Maybe the front is closed but the back is open.*
  - *Or the top is tender and the bottom is tough.*
  - *Maybe energy can flow through some parts of your heart but not all.*
  - *Maybe in some places your heart feels pinched and contracted while in other places it feels spacious.*
- *So where it feels extreme in any of those ways – closed, contracted, contested or callused – you have located some protective parts.*
- *If you want, you can take a little time right now to meet those parts.*
- *If it's okay, just get a little curious about what those protectors are afraid would happen if they allowed you to open your heart fully.*
  - *If they let your heart be tender.*
  - *If they didn't try to contract or compact it.*
- *In answer to that question, you are likely to learn about the vulnerable parts they protect who also live in or around your heart.*
  - *Right now you don't have to go to those vulnerable parts, you can just hear a little bit about them from these protectors.*

- *As you get to know how vigilantly these protectors have guarded your vulnerability, just extend your loving appreciation toward them at whatever degree feels sincere.*
- *Notice how they react to that appreciation.*
- *Right now we are not asking them to change anything. Nor do we expect them to change.*
  - *We're just getting to know their fears and showing them appreciation.*
  - *And someday, if they want, if they feel it's a good idea, they may let you go to those vulnerable parts to heal them.*
  - *Then these hard working protectors will be able to relax and allow you to open your heart.*
- *Often protective parts don't believe healing is possible. They feel condemned to do this with your heart for the rest of your life. So just be sure they know it is possible but there's no pressure.*
- *When this visit with your heart protectors feels complete, you can begin to shift your focus back outside but make sure before you leave to thank them for letting you know all this and thank them for their hard work to keep your heart safe.*

## Exercise

# BEFRIENDING PROTECTORS

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**DIRECTIONS:** When it's time to listen to inner protectors, be sure that you are available.

Scan internally while asking yourself:

- "How do I feel toward this part of \_\_\_\_\_ (the client)?"

If the answer is anything along the spectrum from curiosity to compassion, then it's okay to proceed.

But if the answer is anything else, then you have detected a reactive part in yourself.

Ask the part:

- "What do you need from me in order to let me listen without judging?" (or being afraid, or whatever reaction you have noticed)
- When a reactive part shows up, validate its experience first.
  - "Of course it makes sense that you feel anxious about \_\_\_\_\_ [the client] confronting his boss. Would you be willing to dial the anxiety down so we can learn more about your concerns?"

## Exercise

# THERAPIST'S PARTS WITH EXTREME PROTECTORS

**DIRECTIONS:** Try this exercise with a client whose "activated parts" trigger you and with a client whose "blunted parts" trigger you.

Think of a client who triggers you.

- Bring this person up in your mind's eye.
- Put the person into a room that has a window and a lock on the door.
- Stay outside the room, looking at your client through the window.
- Now see the client do the thing that triggers you.

Notice your parts who get activated and write them down here:

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See if your triggered parts are willing to separate enough so that you can hear them clearly.

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Notice if your client's parts seem activated (hyperaroused) or withdrawn (blunted).

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Notice if your parts get activated or withdrawn in response to your client's parts.

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Now ask your parts to stand behind you for a moment and watch while your Self stays with your client as her or his parts do the triggering thing.

What was it like for your parts to witness your Self being with your client in that moment?

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Would your parts be willing to let you be with your client the next time you see them?

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When this feels complete, invite your client out of the room and thank your parts for showing up to share their experience with you.



## Exercise

# EMBODYING A PART

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**DIRECTIONS:** First find a protective part to check in with and try direct access on yourself by embodying this protector.

Invite the part to embody and show you what it does for you.

- The part may want to move in a certain way.
- It may want to speak (or sing, shout...).
- It may have a particular posture or facial expression it wants you to notice.
  - Ask the part if you're getting it right.

Ask how long it has helped you in this way.

Ask what would happen if it didn't do this job for you.

Ask the part if you are fully getting its role or is there more.

Ask if you can help the part it protects.

## Exercise

# DIRECT ACCESS

**DIRECTIONS:** Direct access is a two-way conversation in which the Self of the therapist speaks directly with the client's target part, periodically asking if the client's Self can be brought in on the conversation. In direct access, the therapist speaks to the part.

You can use direct access with clients or, for practice, you can conduct a role-play with a colleague or embody one of your client's protective parts by going back and forth between being the therapist and the client, either changing chairs or shifting a bit to one side and then the other on a couch. Try this exercise with a protector.

1. "I want to talk to this protective part directly. Are you there?"

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2. "What do you do for \_\_\_\_\_ [Marianne]?"

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3. "How long have you had this job?"

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4. "How's it going?"

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5. "What are you concerned would happen if you stopped?"

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6. "If we could help that part (the one who would take over and do something problematic if this part were to stop), would you still need to do this job?"

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7. "Have you met the \_\_\_\_\_ [Marianne] who's not a part?"

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8. "Would you like to meet her? She can help you and the parts you're worried about."

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9. "Will you give \_\_\_\_\_ [Marianne] permission to help the part you're worried about if it agrees not to take her over?"

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## Exercise

# NEGOTIATING BILATERAL DISARMAMENT WITH POLARIZED PARTS

Ask your inner system:

- "Please let me hear all opinions about this problem, taking turns. I will write down what you say."

Write down everything you hear, noticing contradictions or disagreements (polarities).

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Ask these parts:

- "Which part, or team of parts, needs my attention first?"

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Then go back to the cornerstone question:

- "How do you feel toward [the target part]?"

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If the answer is a C word that indicates Self-energy (see 8C's in glossary), then proceed with interviewing the target part using the 6F's. If the answer is anything else, then another part is reacting. Help that part unblend (differentiate) so that you can interview the target part.

## Exercise

# INTRODUCING A PROTECTOR TO THE SELF

**DIRECTIONS:** Think of some situation that has occurred during your life in which you felt threatened and had the impulse to defend yourself – this does not have to be something extreme. It can be recent or from the more distant past.

Take a moment to imagine yourself back in that moment in time.

- You will have an action urge - notice where it is located and what your body wants to do.
  - If you are alone and feel comfortable moving, go ahead and make that gesture.
  - Or picture yourself making that gesture in your mind's eye.
- ◊ Repeat the gesture a few times.

Ask your protector how long it has been doing this job. Write down what you hear.

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Ask your protector what it believes would happen if it stopped doing its job. Write down what you hear.

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Ask your protector who it protects. Write down what you hear. Sometimes protectors are reluctant to share who they protect. Don't push them, find out what they need in order to trust you more.

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If it did share who it protects, set an intention to do so, write that down here and work with the vulnerability in a way that is familiar to you.

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If your protector is uncomfortable sharing with you who it protects, stay curious (or, if you are not curious, help reactive parts to differentiate) and inquire about what they need to trust you more.

- If it says something along the lines of: "You will be overwhelmed by that vulnerable part," thank it and ask for permission to communicate with the part about not being overwhelming.
  - Then ask the exile if, in return for getting the attention it needs, it would be willing to stay separate and not overwhelm.
- If it says: "You are not capable of helping that part" ask it if it would be willing to try an experiment to get to know you better.
  - Ask it how old it thinks you are.
  - Ask it if it is willing to meet the you of today, your Self.
  - Give it time to check you out and get to know you.
  - See if it is willing to look you in the eyes.
  - Ask it, "What is it like to meet me?"
  - And, "Can I have your permission now to help that vulnerable part?"



## MEET YOUR PROTECTOR EXERCISES

**DIRECTIONS:** Use this template to get to know your protectors. Look over our list of common protector roles and add any we don't mention that are relevant for you.

Notice if this protector is proactive for you (trying to stop feelings from arising) or reactive for you (trying to distract from feelings).

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Once you have permission to get to know this protector, ask:

What does it believe would happen if it stopped doing its job? Write down what you hear.

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Who does it protect? Write down what you hear.

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Ask for permission to help the part it protects.

If it did share who it protects, set an intention to do so, write that down here and work with the vulnerability in a way that is familiar to you.

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If your protector is uncomfortable giving you permission to help that part, stay curious.

- Or, if you are not curious, help your reactive parts to unblend and ask why.

If it says something along the lines of: "You will be overwhelmed by that vulnerable part," ask for permission to ask the exile to not overwhelm.

- Then ask the exile if, in return for getting the attention it needs, would it be willing to stay differentiated and not overwhelm.

If it says: "You are not capable of helping that part," ask it if it would be willing to get to know you better.

- Then ask it to look you in the eye and let you know who it sees there.

If it sees a reactive part, take a moment to help that part differentiate.

If it sees some quality of Self, ask, "What is it like to meet me?"

- And, "Do I have your permission now to help that vulnerable part who you protect?"

## Exercise

# AN ENDLESS SUPPLY OF PROTECTIVE STRATEGIES

**DIRECTIONS:** The protectors who often show up in traumatized individuals include dissociation, inner and outer shamers, overwork, keeping-a-low-profile, compliance, anxiety, rage, revenge, suicide, sex addiction, mood-altering substances, intimacy-seeking and intimacy-avoidant, eating, exercise, appearance obsession, somatizing, and intellectualizing.

If you notice protectors in your system who are missing from our list, add them below:

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## Exercise

# FIND YOUR LEGACY BURDENS

**DIRECTIONS:** Create a family genogram that includes as much as you know (or can find out) about your extended family. There are free online websites that offer a variety of options for types of genograms (for example, <http://www.genopro.com/Default-New.aspx>).

In your genogram:

- Highlight trauma in general and note specific issues you want to track like alcohol, divorce, domestic violence, incest, multiple childbirths, unsafe living conditions, slavery, racism, substance abuse, war, genocide, starvation, immigration, and the like.
- Also include the positive, such as particular gifts and talents: musical, good at math, mechanical, relationally skilled.

For example:

My maternal grandparents:

- Mary
  - Grew up in New York city, daughter of immigrants from Ireland who worked in factories, alcoholic father, 10 siblings, 2 died in infancy.
- Colin
  - Grew up in upstate New York, the son of a plumber and a housewife who had a "nervous breakdown" when Colin was 10 years old.
- Their children
  - My mother, Sybil
  - Aunt Eleanor
  - Uncle Edward (died accidentally at 15 years old)

My parents:

- Sybil: school teacher
- Joseph: accountant
  - My siblings and me
    - ◊ Me
    - ◊ Liam: housepainter, alcohol problem, 1 child
    - ◊ Marie: nurse, 2 children

Aunt Eleanor: gave up ambition to be an opera singer

- Her husband Al: car mechanic
  - My cousins
    - ◊ Sharon: talented singer, no children
    - ◊ Dale: works as an actuary, 3 children

Notice repeating patterns of strength and vulnerability in the ancestral map and write them down below, use extra paper as needed.

Strengths:

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Vulnerabilities:

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Choose an ancestral vulnerability that also resides in you and has influenced your life.

- Turn your attention inside and ask permission to pay attention to this vulnerability.
- If there are concerns, listen to them and either set an intention to return to this with the help of a therapist or, if you get permission, proceed.
- Notice the vulnerability in, on or around your body.
- Ask the following question and write down what you hear without censoring or thinking:
  - What percentage of this vulnerability belongs to me, and what percentage belongs to my parents (or someone else from your early life)?

\_\_\_\_\_ % belongs to me.

\_\_\_\_\_ % belongs to \_\_\_\_\_.

## THERAPIST CHECK-IN BETWEEN SESSIONS

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- Close your eyes (if that feels comfortable) and ask inside if your previous client triggered any of your parts.
- Ask your parts if they need anything from you now. See if they are willing to relax.
  - If not, set an intention with them to follow-up at a later time – and be specific about when you will check back with them – and then ask them to go into a waiting room (in your mind) while you see your next client.
- Make room inside to bring Self-energy to the experience of being triggered by your last client.
- When those parts step back, notice the internal space that is created.
- Now ask if your parts feel apprehensive about your next client.
  - Listen to their concerns and let them know that they can rest near you during the session or, if it would feel more comfortable, they can go into a waiting room.
  - Ask if they can trust your Self to handle the next session.
- Again, connect with your Self before you proceed with your next client.